

mechanised gaze of the dour panoptic vision can now be said to be mimicked, pleasurably, in the voyeuristic experience, where visibility emerges as a bait for both the lusting and the lusted after. The strict separation between the two, of viewer and viewed, is also essential to the voyeur's enterprise, just as it is fundamental to Foucault's conception of discipline and punish; we can draw a parallel between the (assumed, antagonistic) power of the voyeur and the pinned-on-the-wall helplessness of the viewed, which is of course complicated when one comes to the voyeur today as primarily embodied by/in MMS uploads and downloads.

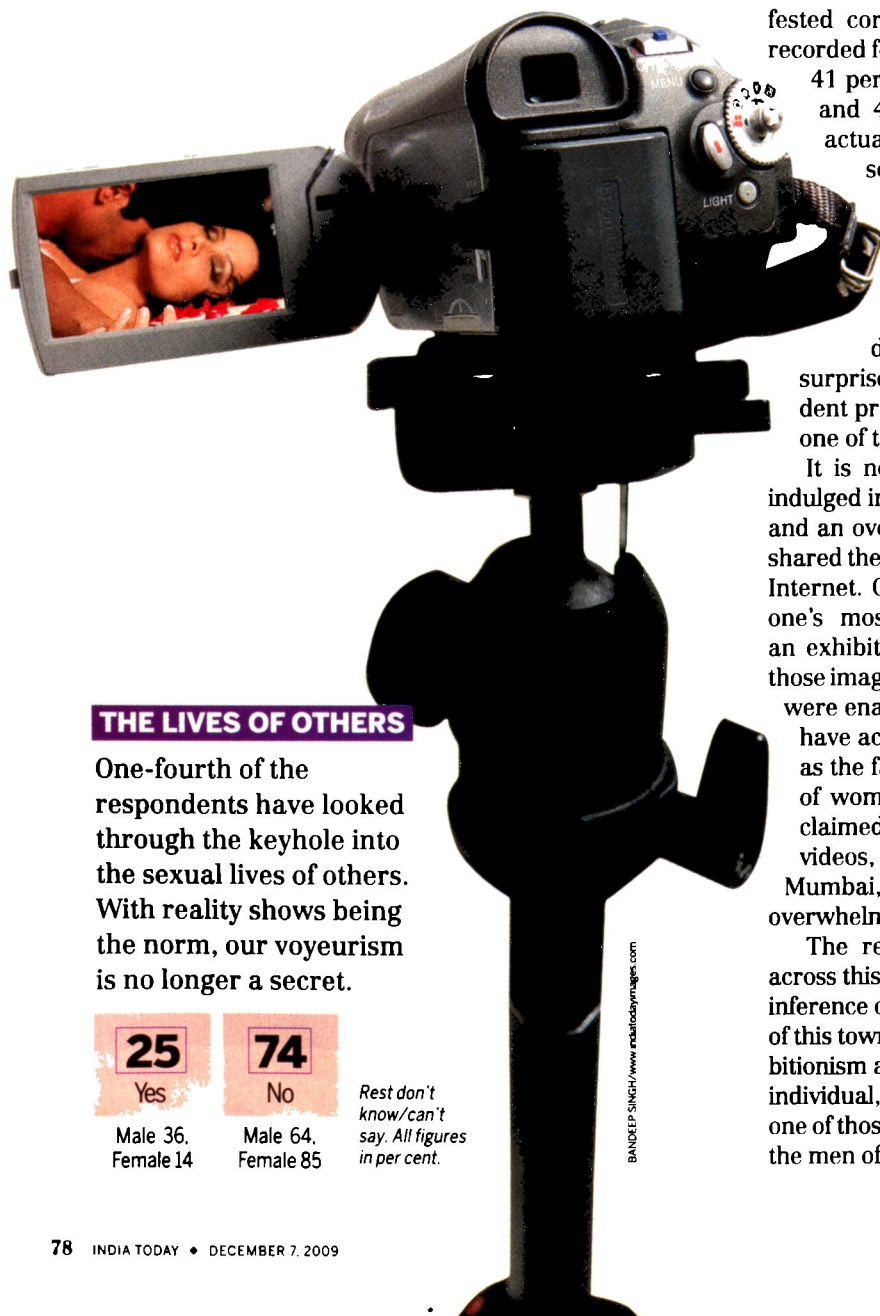
The first set of questions in this section, not surprisingly, addresses the MMS phenomenon that has exploded the apparently-hitherto-hidden voyeuristic fantasies embedded in our national psyche, if our multimedia are to be believed. Since there is no denying that the arrival of

mobile phones with cameras in them has single-handedly been responsible for our video-recording pandemic (pun and irony both intended), it may be a revelation then that of those surveyed, a modest 12 per cent of men (highest in Ludhiana and Bangalore) and a timid 4 per cent of women (highest in Mumbai) overall admitted to fantasising about recording their sexual activity for an MMS. The hypothesis that the MMS has burgeoned into the single-most scintillating, titillating aspect of sexual action across the country may therefore be something of an exaggeration; it is also intriguing that according to this survey, fantasising about MMS sex (for want of a better term) is hardly indulged in by the non-married. This might then challenge our general assumption that the MMS sex phenomenon is rampant amongst youth, who tend to be savvy about, amongst other things, techno-gadgets and their functional plenitude. It is rather enthralling to think, instead, that mature marital bedrooms, as opposed to stealthily-passionate teen-infested corners, are hotbeds of intimate activity being recorded for posterity by the roving eye of a video camera:

41 per cent of women who fantasised about MMS sex, and 44 per cent of men who did, then admit to actually having lived out their fantasies on the video screen, 56 per cent of the men belonging to the middle class. A 21st century consumerist modernity, of which the mobile phone, with camera, may well be the most striking icon, has perhaps most insidiously as well as most widely insinuated itself into the extensive middle classes of India, so this comes as little surprise. It also matches the information in the respondent profile of the men in the survey that almost every one of them owns a mobile phone.

It is not surprising to see that amongst those who indulged in MMS sex, more than half the number of women and an overwhelming majority of men (80 per cent) then shared the recording with friends and/or uploaded it on the Internet. One might deduce that the desire to videotape one's most intimate sexual moments is spawned of an exhibitionist yearning that would want to then take those images beyond the confines of the space in which they were enacted; now that 75 per cent of the men surveyed have access to the Internet, this transference is as easy as the fantasising in the first place. Far fewer numbers of women (about 8 per cent) and men (17 per cent) claimed to have seen their friends or relatives in MMS sex videos, the sightings being highest for women in Mumbai, Delhi, Ludhiana and Ahmedabad, and overwhelmingly high for men in Ludhiana.

The recurrence of Ludhiana in high-number spots across this segment of the survey may be compelling for an inference of a nature that has nothing to do with the profile of this town in particular: that though propensities for exhibitionism and voyeurism need not necessarily coexist in an individual, it appears to be likelier that those who possess one of those inclinations would also own the other. Amongst the men of Ludhiana, especially, the following readings are



## THE LIVES OF OTHERS

One-fourth of the respondents have looked through the keyhole into the sexual lives of others. With reality shows being the norm, our voyeurism is no longer a secret.

**25**

Yes

Male 36,  
Female 14

**74**

No

Male 64,  
Female 85

Rest don't  
know/can't  
say. All figures  
in per cent.

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